WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY, 1918–1939

KEY TOPIC 1: THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC, 1918–1929

Student Master Textbook • Core Knowledge, Disciplinary Enquiries & Archival Evidence



Plate I: Potsdamer Platz and the Traffic Tower in Golden Twenties Berlin (c. 1924–1928) Historical Primary Photograph

OFFICIAL PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION STRUCTURE & SYLLABUS MAPPING (OPTION 31: KT1)

Core syllabus coverage across all four key enquiries:

1. ORIGINS OF REPUBLIC, 1918–19

- Legacy of WW1: abdication of Kaiser, armistice and revolution, 1918–19.
- Setting up of Weimar Republic: National Assembly and new constitution.
- Strengths and weaknesses of new constitution (Proportional Representation, Article 48).

2. EARLY CHALLENGES, 1919–23

- Reasons for unpopularity: stab in the back (*Dolchstoßlegende*) and Versailles Treaty.
- Political challenges: Spartacist Uprising, Kapp Putsch, and political assassinations.
- Economic challenges: French occupation of Ruhr (1923), causes and effects of hyperinflation.

3. RECOVERY OF REPUBLIC, 1924–29

- Economic recovery: Stresemann, Rentenmark, Dawes Plan (1924), US loans, Young Plan (1929).
- Foreign policy: Locarno Treaties (1925), League of Nations (1926), Kellogg-Briand (1928).
- Impact on domestic political stability and reduced extremist support.

4. CHANGES IN SOCIETY, 1924–29

- Standard of living: changes in wages, housing, and 1927 unemployment insurance.
- Position of women: politics (voting, deputies), work (double-earners), leisure ('New Woman').
- Cultural changes: developments in architecture (Bauhaus), art (*Neue Sachlichkeit*), and cinema.

KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

Key Enquiry: Out of the ashes: How did the devastating legacy of the First World War forge the Weimar Republic, and were the democratic foundations of its new Constitution fatally flawed from the start? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE LEGACY OF THE FIRST WORLD WAR: A NATION ON THE BRINK

[1.1] **The Military Collapse & The Autumn Crisis:** By late September 1918, Germany's imperial military leadership realized the First World War was utterly lost. General Erich Ludendorff informed Kaiser Wilhelm II that the German army could no longer withstand the Allied Hundred Days Offensive. Fearing an imminent military rout and hoping for lenient peace terms based on US President Woodrow Wilson's Fourteen Points, the High Command urgently advised the creation of a civilian parliamentary government. The human and economic devastation was staggering: over two million German soldiers had been killed, four million were wounded (representing a 55% casualty rate), and imperial debt had surged from 50 billion to 150 billion marks.

[1.2] **The Starving Home Front & The Royal Navy Blockade:** Behind the crumbling battle lines, civilian society was fracturing under acute deprivation. The British Royal Navy's tight naval blockade choked off essential imports of food, fertilizers, and medical supplies. During the freezing 'Turnip Winter' of 1916–17 and throughout 1918, over 750,000 German civilians died from starvation, hypothermia, and malnutrition-related illnesses, compounded by the lethal Spanish Influenza pandemic. Bitter civilian resentment erupted into mass strikes across Berlin, Essen, and Munich, as industrial workers protested against starvation rations, war profiteering, and the military regime.

[1.3] **The Kiel Mutiny & The Spread of Soldiers' Councils:** The final spark ignited on 28 October 1918 at the naval base of Wilhelmshaven. Ordered by admiral commanders to embark on a suicidal "death voyage" against the British Grand Fleet, naval crews refused orders and extinguished boiler fires. When officers arrested hundreds of mutineers, 40,000 armed sailors seized the port of Kiel on 3 November, forming revolutionary Sailors' and Workers' Councils (*Räte*). Within days, the revolt spread across northern Germany: soldiers refused to fire on demonstrators, and in Bavaria on 7 November, socialist Kurt Eisner proclaimed a People's State, overthrowing the Wittelsbach monarchy.

ACT 2 REVOLUTION FROM BELOW: MUTINY & ABDICATION

[2.1] **The Kaiser's Abdication & Flight to Holland:** On 9 November 1918, revolutionary turmoil engulfed the capital. In Berlin, general strikes brought industrial production to a complete standstill, while armed workers and mutinous soldiers marched toward the government quarter. Recognizing that the army would no longer obey the crown, Chancellor Prince Max von Baden took decisive action without royal consent: he publicly announced the abdication of Kaiser Wilhelm II. Stripped of imperial command, Wilhelm II fled his military headquarters at Spa, boarding an armored train into permanent exile at Amerongen in the Netherlands, ending five centuries of Hohenzollern rule.

[2.2] **Proclaiming the Republic & The Dual Balcony Threat:** Desperate to forestall a violent Bolshevik-style insurrection, Prince Max handed the Chancellorship to Friedrich Ebert, leader of the moderate Social Democratic Party (SPD). At 2:00 PM on 9 November, SPD deputy Philipp Scheidemann leaned from a Reichstag window and proclaimed a democratic German Republic to cheering crowds. Two hours later, radical communist leader Karl Liebknecht appeared on a balcony of the former imperial palace and declared a "Free Socialist Republic". Ebert's provisional government immediately established the six-man Council of People's Representatives to govern through the dangerous vacuum.

[2.3] **The Ebert-Groener Pact & The Stinnes-Legien Compromise:** Facing immediate armed threats from communist revolutionaries, Ebert concluded a secret telephone pact with General Wilhelm Groener on 10 November 1918. The Imperial Army promised loyalty to the new socialist-led republic in exchange for Ebert's guarantee that traditional military command structures would remain untouched and revolutionary councils suppressed. On 11 November, civilian politician Matthias Erzberger signed the Armistice in the Compiègne forest. However, right-wing nationalists immediately weaponized this surrender to forge the toxic *Dolchstoßlegende* ('stab-in-the-back' myth), branding democratic politicians 'November Criminals'.

SOURCE A OFFICIAL PROCLAMATION 9 November 1918

Philipp Scheidemann Proclaims the Republic from the Reichstag Window

> *"The German people have won all along the line. What was old and rotten has collapsed; militarism is at an end! The Hohenzollerns have abdicated! Long live the German Republic! Ebert has been charged with forming a government... See to it that the new Republic is not endangered by anything. Long live the free German Republic!"*

Spoken spontaneously from a window of the Reichstag in Berlin on the afternoon of 9 November 1918 to pre-empt communist leader Karl Liebknecht from proclaiming a Soviet Republic from the nearby royal palace.

HINGE QUESTION: *Did Scheidemann's proclamation create a genuine democratic mandate, or did it expose the deep ideological divisions that doomed the Republic?*

SOURCE B CONSTITUTIONAL CHARTER 11 August 1919

Articles 22 and 48 of the Weimar Constitution

> *"Article 22: The Reichstag shall be elected by universal, equal, direct and secret ballot by all men and women over twenty years of age, in accordance with the principles of proportional representation...*
>
> *Article 48: If public safety and order in the Reich are seriously disturbed or endangered, the Reich President may take the measures necessary to restore public safety and order, intervening if necessary with the aid of the armed forces."*

Drafted by liberal jurist Hugo Preuss, the Constitution created Europe's most democratic franchise while simultaneously introducing the emergency decree loophole that ultimately enabled authoritarian rule.

HINGE QUESTION: *Was Article 48 a necessary emergency safety valve for a fragile democracy, or a constitutional suicide pill?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.1 EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

PROPORTIONAL REPRESENTATION
Electoral system where parties gain seats precisely proportional to national votes, causing coalition instability.

ARTICLE 48
Emergency constitutional clause allowing the President to rule by decree without parliamentary consent.

DOLCHSTOSSLEGENDE
The toxic right-wing myth that the German army was undefeated in the field but stabbed in the back by democratic politicians.

EBERT-GROENER PACT
Secret pact where the army pledged loyalty to the civilian government in exchange for state autonomy and suppressing communism.

KT1.1: The Origins of the Republic, 1918–1919

ACT 3 FLIGHT FROM BERLIN: THE NATIONAL ASSEMBLY CONVENED IN WEIMAR (JAN–FEB 1919)

[4.1] In January 1919, Ebert's provisional government held nationwide elections for a National Assembly under full universal suffrage for all men and women aged twenty and above. With an extraordinary 82% turnout, moderate democratic parties—the SPD, Catholic Centre Party, and liberal DDP—won 76% of seats, giving the new republic a powerful democratic mandate. Friedrich Ebert was formally elected by the Assembly as the Republic's first President.

[4.2] Because Berlin was paralyzed by political unrest and armed street fighting from the Spartacist Uprising, the National Assembly could not safely convene in the capital. Delegates gathered 150 miles south in the peaceful cultural town of Weimar on 6 February 1919, convening in the *Deutsches Nationaltheater* (**Source C**). Meeting in Weimar insulated politicians from mob pressure while invoking the humanist legacy of Goethe and Schiller, signaling to the victorious Allies that Germany had rejected Prussian militarism.

[3.2] **The Democratic Transition & Elections of January 1919:** Friedrich Ebert formed the Council of People's Representatives, declared an armistice, and scheduled national elections for 19 January 1919. Despite radical communist boycotts, 30 million Germans voted—an extraordinary 83% turnout providing an overwhelming democratic mandate for the National Assembly to convene at Weimar.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE SECRET TELEPHONE AGREEMENT 10 November 1918

General Wilhelm Groener on the Ebert-Groener Pact

"On the evening of 10 November, I telephoned Friedrich Ebert in the Chancellery over our secret line... I informed him that the High Command placed itself at the disposal of his government. In return, the Field Marshal and I expected the government to support the officer corps in maintaining discipline, supply the army, and combat revolutionary Bolshevism with all vigor. Ebert accepted our offer of alliance with deep relief."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1871–1925



Friedrich Ebert
LEADER OF THE SPD & FIRST PRESIDENT OF THE WEIMAR REPUBLIC (1919–1925)

Steered Germany through imperial collapse, concluded the Armistice, and negotiated the democratic constitution while suppressing violent revolts.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Formed the provisional Council of People's Representatives on 10 November 1918 following the Kaiser's abdication.
- Forged the secret Ebert-Groener Pact with the Imperial Army to maintain public order and suppress communist insurrection.
- Convened the National Assembly at Weimar and signed the democratic Constitution into law on 11 August 1919.

ACT 4 THE WEIMAR CONSTITUTION: PROGRESSIVE UNIVERSAL SUFFRAGE AND FATAL EMERGENCY POWERS (AUG 1919)

[5.1] Promulgated on 11 August 1919, the new Weimar Constitution contained distinct **strengths and weaknesses** that shaped Germany's democratic destiny. Among its major **strengths** was its thoroughly democratic architecture: it enshrined a progressive Bill of Rights guaranteeing freedom of speech, assembly, and religion. It established universal suffrage for citizens aged twenty and over, an elected President, and a parliament (**Reichstag**) elected every four years under **Proportional Representation (PR)**, alongside the **Reichsrat** representing eighteen federal states.

[5.2] However, critical constitutional **weaknesses** undermined political stability. Proportional representation allocated seats based on exact vote percentages, allowing dozens of tiny extremist parties to gain seats. This made single-party majorities impossible, forcing twenty-nine unstable coalition governments between 1919 and 1933. Most dangerously, **Article 48** empowered the President to suspend civil rights and rule by emergency decree without Reichstag consent—a dictatorial emergency loophole that would ultimately enable the destruction of the Republic.

[4.2] **The National Assembly at Weimar & The Democratic Compromise:** Meeting in the peaceful cultural city of Weimar to escape Berlin's street riots, delegates drafted Germany's first parliamentary constitution. Ratified on 11 August 1919, the document balanced progressive universal suffrage with traditional federal structures, establishing a republic amid revolutionary turmoil.

[4.3] **Constitutional Architecture & The Preuss Compromise:** Lead architect Hugo Preuss sought to dismantle imperial Prussian dominance, though conservative delegates successfully preserved traditional regional prerogatives.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE WAS WEIMAR DOOMED FROM BIRTH?

Interpretation A: Structural Fatalism (Eberhard Kolb)
"Weimar democracy was crippled from its inception. Pure proportional representation guaranteed fragmented coalitions, while Article 48 planted a constitutional dictatorship mechanism that fatally compromised democratic governance."

Interpretation B: Elite Sabotage (Richard J. Evans)
"The constitution was a remarkably progressive charter. Its vulnerability stemmed not from legal text, but because conservative civil servants, judges, and military commanders remained in power, actively sabotaging democratic legitimacy."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ENQUIRY 1.1 SEQUENCE

29 Sep 1918 • The Military Collapse
Ludendorff informs the Kaiser the war is lost and urges parliamentary reform to secure lenient terms from Wilson.

28 Oct–3 Nov 1918 • The Kiel Naval Mutiny
Sailors at Wilhelmshaven and Kiel extinguish boilers and refuse a suicide mission, establishing revolutionary councils.

9 Nov 1918 • Abdication & Republic
Prince Max proclaims the Kaiser's abdication; Ebert becomes Chancellor and Scheidemann proclaims the Republic.

11 Aug 1919 • Weimar Constitution Signed
President Ebert signs the democratic constitution, introducing universal suffrage and PR, alongside Article 48.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A QUESTION 1 • 4 MARKS • 5 MINS

Exam Challenge: Give two things you can infer from Source A about the establishment of the Weimar Republic in November 1918. [4 marks]

Specification Technique: State 2 distinct historical inferences directly supported by explicit quotes or visual evidence from Source A. GRADE 9 ACCURACY

KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

Key Enquiry: Surrounded by enemies: How did the Weimar Republic survive the traumatic birth of the Treaty of Versailles, violent uprisings from the extreme left and right, and the catastrophic economic collapse of 1923? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE DIKTAT OF VERSAILLES: WAR GUILT, REPARATIONS AND THE 'STAB IN THE BACK' LEGEND (JUN 1919)

[1.1] The principal cause of the **early unpopularity of the Republic** was the humiliation of the **Treaty of Versailles**, signed under protest on 28 June 1919. Denounced across Germany as an intolerable **Diktat** (dictated peace), the treaty imposed devastating terms. Under **Article 231 (the War Guilt Clause)**, Germany accepted sole blame for causing the war, justifying astronomical financial reparations fixed in 1921 at 132 billion gold marks (£6.6 billion). Germany lost 13% of its European territory, including Alsace-Lorraine to France and West Prussia to Poland to create the Polish Corridor, stripping 10% of its population and 16% of its coalfields.

[1.2] Military clauses capped the German army at 100,000 volunteers, abolished conscription, banned all tanks, submarines, and combat aircraft, and demilitarised the Rhineland. Because censorship had hidden the army's retreat and no Allied troops had invaded German soil, right-wing nationalists propagated the **'stab in the back' theory** (*Dolchstoßlegende*) (**Source A**). They falsely claimed the heroic army was betrayed at home by socialist and Jewish politicians—scornfully branded the **"November Criminals"**—sowing permanent hatred against the new democratic system.

[1.2] **The Diplomatic Outrage & Economic Amputation:** When the treaty draft was presented at Versailles on 7 May 1919, Foreign Minister Count Ulrich von Brockdorff-Rantzau fiercely declared: "We know the impact of the hate that faces us here... The demand that we alone should confess to war guilt is an outrage." Beyond territorial amputations, Germany lost 75% of its zinc and iron ore deposits in Upper Silesia and Lorraine, 26% of coal production, and 15% of agricultural output. Stripped of merchant shipping, overseas colonies, and economic resources, the infant republic was plunged into chronic fiscal instability.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH January 1919

Government Machine-Gun Post on the Brandenburg Gate (Spartacist Uprising)



In January 1919, the communist Spartacus League launched an armed revolt in Berlin. Government troops and Freikorps units set up machine-gun positions behind the Quadriga atop the Brandenburg Gate to defend the government district before ruthlessly crushing the uprising and murdering Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the government's decision to deploy right-wing Freikorps to crush left-wing revolutionaries prove to be a fatal compromise for Weimar democracy?*

ACT 2 RED FLAGS IN BERLIN: THE SPARTACIST UPRISING AND THE FREIKORPS BLOODBATH (JAN 1919)

[2.1] The fragile Republic was immediately assaulted from Left and Right. In January 1919, left-wing revolutionaries known as the **Spartacists** (the communist Spartacus League led by **Rosa Luxemburg** and **Karl Liebknecht**) attempted to overthrow Ebert's government and establish a Soviet-style proletarian dictatorship. Over 100,000 armed industrial workers staged mass strikes in central Berlin, seizing railway termini and major newspaper printing offices.

[2.2] Lacking reliable police, Defence Minister Gustav Noske unleashed the **Freikorps**—volunteer paramilitary brigades of demobilized imperial soldiers who were violently anti-communist. Armed with machine guns, flamethrowers, and artillery, 4,000 Freikorps troops brutally crushed the Spartacist uprising within a week, killing over 100 workers. On 15 January, Luxemburg and Liebknecht were arrested, beaten, and murdered without trial. This bloodshed created an unbridgeable division between the SPD and the Communist Party, crippling future working-class unity against fascism.

[3.1] Extreme right-wing paramilitary challenges erupted in March 1920 during the **Kapp Putsch**. When Ebert's government attempted to disband the 5,000-strong Freikorps Marinebrigade Ehrhardt to comply with Versailles treaty troop limits, nationalist officers revolted. Led by General Walther von Lüttwitz and civil servant **Wolfgang Kapp**, the Freikorps marched into Berlin with swastikas painted on their helmets (**Source B**), seizing government ministries and forcing Ebert's cabinet to flee to Dresden.

[3.2] When Ebert pleaded with army commander General Hans von Seeckt to order regular troops to defend the government, Seeckt flatly refused, declaring *"Reichswehr does not fire upon Reichswehr."* In response, the SPD government appealed to the trade unions to launch a nationwide **general strike**. Over 12 million workers paralyzed gas, water, electricity, and rail transit across Berlin. Unable to govern a paralyzed capital, the Kapp Putsch collapsed in four days, proving that working-class solidarity could defend democracy when the military refused. These violent uprisings from Left and Right: **Spartacists, Freikorps, the Kapp Putsch.** showed that the Republic was under constant armed threat.

SOURCE B ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH Autumn 1923

Stacks of Devalued Paper Currency in a Berlin Bank (1923)



Following the Franco-Belgian occupation of the Ruhr in January 1923 and the government's policy of passive resistance, the Reichsbank printed unbacked paper marks day and night. Here, bank clerks sit behind head-high stacks of bundled notes as a single loaf of bread rose to over 200 billion marks.

HINGE QUESTION: *How did the hyperinflation crisis of 1923 permanently destroy the economic security and political faith of Germany's middle class?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.2

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

DIKTAT
A dictated peace; German term for Versailles because Germany was locked out of negotiations and forced to sign under threat of invasion.

FREIKORPS
Paramilitary units of fiercely anti-communist, nationalist demobilised soldiers organized to crush revolutionary uprisings.

PASSIVE RESISTANCE
Non-violent strike policy adopted by Ruhr miners in 1923, refusing to mine coal for French occupying forces.

HYPERINFLATION
Catastrophic currency collapse in 1923 where paper marks became worthless and prices rose out of control.

KT1.2: Early Challenges to the Republic, 1919–1923

ACT 3 BULLETS FROM THE SHADOWS: THE ASSASSINATIONS OF ERZBERGER AND RATHENAU (1921–1922)

[4.1] Between 1919 and 1922, ultra-nationalist right-wing murder syndicates like **Organisation Consul** waged a ruthless campaign of political assassinations against republican leaders. In total, 376 political assassinations occurred, 354 committed by right-wing nationalists. In August 1921, right-wing gunmen murdered **Matthias Erzberger**, the politician who had signed the 1918 armistice, shooting him while he walked in the Black Forest.

[4.2] In June 1922, assassins gunned down Foreign Minister **Walther Rathenau**, a brilliant Jewish industrialist and statesman who had negotiated the Rapallo Treaty with Soviet Russia. Over one million Germans marched in mass funeral demonstrations against right-wing terrorism. However, the conservative judiciary treated right-wing murderers with scandalous leniency: their prison sentences averaged just four months, while left-wing assassins were frequently executed, revealing deep institutional hostility toward the Republic.

[3.2] **National Outrage & Republic Protection Act:** Rathenau's murder provoked mass grief, driving 700,000 citizens into Berlin's streets. Chancellor Joseph Wirth enacted the Law for the Protection of the Republic to dissolve extremist leagues, but nationalist regional courts continually undermined its enforcement.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE THE PEACE TREATY 28 June 1919

Article 231 of the Treaty of Versailles (The War Guilt Clause)

"The Allied and Associated Governments affirm and Germany accepts the responsibility of Germany and her allies for causing all the loss and damage to which the Allied and Associated Governments and their nationals have been subjected as a consequence of the war imposed upon them by the aggression of Germany and her allies."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1871–1919



Rosa Luxemburg
CO-FOUNDER OF THE SPARTACUS LEAGUE & GERMAN COMMUNIST PARTY (KPD)

Brilliant Marxist theorist and orator who led the January 1919 Berlin insurrection against the moderate SPD government before being murdered by Freikorps officers.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Co-founded the radical anti-war Spartacus League in 1916, publishing underground revolutionary tracts.
- Demanded all power be transferred to Workers' and Soldiers' Councils rather than a parliamentary National Assembly.
- Arrested, beaten, and murdered alongside Karl Liebknecht by Freikorps soldiers on 15 January 1919, her body dumped in the Landwehr Canal.

ACT 4 FRENCH TROOPS IN THE RUHR & THE MARK COLLAPSES: THE NIGHTMARE OF HYPERINFLATION (1923)

[5.1] In January 1923, Germany faced dual economic and geopolitical catastrophes. When Germany defaulted on timber and coal reparations, 60,000 French and Belgian troops launched the **French occupation of the Ruhr**—seizing Germany's industrial heartland which produced 80% of its coal and steel. Chancellor Wilhelm Cuno ordered a campaign of **passive resistance**: miners, railwaymen, and steelworkers struck, refusing to collaborate. The occupying French forces placed the Ruhr under martial law, expelling 150,000 civilians and shooting over 130 striking workers.

[5.2] To sustain striking Ruhr workers and replace lost tax revenue, the Weimar government printed astronomical sums of unbacked paper banknotes, triggering catastrophic **hyperinflation**. By November 1923, one US dollar was worth 4.2 trillion marks, and a loaf of bread cost 201 billion marks. The Reichsbank issued one-trillion-mark banknotes (**Source C**), and workers carried daily wages in wheelbarrows. While industrial debtors paid off loans cheaply, the life savings, war bonds, and pensions of the patriotic middle class were wiped out completely, permanently destroying faith in the Republic.

[4.2] **The Barter Economy & Everyday Chaos:** By late 1923, money lost all function: workers were paid twice daily in wheelbarrows of cash to purchase bread before prices doubled by lunchtime. Commerce reverted to crude bartering of coal, shoes, and sausages.

FLASHPOINT IN FOCUS: ECONOMIC CATASTROPHE THE RUHR OCCUPATION • 1923

The Ruhr Crisis & The Hyperinflation Spiral

When Germany defaulted on timber and coal deliveries in late 1922, French Prime Minister Raymond Poincaré ordered 60,000 French and Belgian troops to occupy the Ruhr industrial heartland in January 1923 to seize reparations in kind. Chancellor Wilhelm Cuno ordered passive resistance: workers went on general strike while French troops sealed off the region, cutting off 80% of German coal and iron production. To pay striking miners and keep the state functioning, the Reichsbank printed astronomical quantities of paper marks, triggering the catastrophic hyperinflation collapse.

Psychological Ruin: Middle-class Germans saw their life savings, pensions, and insurance policies utterly wiped out overnight. They never forgave the Weimar Republic for their humiliation, creating fertile soil for extremist recruitment.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE THE TRAUMA OF 1923: PERMANENT SCAR OR RESILIENCE?

Interpretation A: Middle-Class Alienation (Detlev Peukert)

"Hyperinflation destroyed the moral foundation of the Republic. Middle-class citizens whose savings evaporated felt utterly betrayed by democracy, creating deep cynicism that made them fertile ground for later radicalization."

Interpretation B: Institutional Resilience (Mary Fulbrook)

"Despite extreme crises—Ruhr occupation, hyperinflation, and armed rebellions from left and right—the Republic did not collapse in 1923. The decisive introduction of the Rentenmark proved the state possessed vital resilience."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ENQUIRY 1.2 SEQUENCE

5–12 Jan 1919 • The Spartacist Uprising
Communist revolt in Berlin is crushed by the Freikorps; leaders Rosa Luxemburg and Karl Liebknecht are murdered.

28 Jun 1919 • Treaty of Versailles Signed
Weimar envoys sign the treaty under protest, accepting £6.6bn reparations, military curbs, and Article 231 guilt.

13–17 Mar 1920 • The Kapp Putsch
Freikorps brigades seize Berlin; the Reichswehr refuses to fire, but an SPD general strike collapses the coup.

Jan–Nov 1923 • Ruhr Crisis & Hyperinflation
French occupation prompts passive resistance; government money-printing causes astronomical hyperinflation.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A QUESTION 2 • 12 MARKS • 18 MINS

Exam Challenge: Explain why the Treaty of Versailles caused significant challenges for the Weimar Republic in the years 1919–1923. [12 marks]

Specification Stimulus: (1) Reparations • (2) The 'stab-in-the-back' myth (Dolchstoßlegende) • *Deploy 3 PEEL paragraphs with precise causal evidence.* GRADE 9 CAUSATION

KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

Key Enquiry: Dancing on a volcano: Did Gustav Stresemann genuinely rescue the Weimar Republic from the ashes of 1923, or was Germany's 'Golden Age' built on quicksand? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 BURNING THE TRILLION-MARK NOTES: STRESEMANN AND THE MIRACLE OF THE RENTENMARK (NOV 1923)

[1.1] In August 1923, at the catastrophic climax of the Ruhr crisis, **Gustav Stresemann** was appointed Chancellor and Foreign Minister. Acting with extraordinary courage, Stresemann ended passive resistance in the Ruhr in September 1923 despite furious nationalist outcry, halting the ruinous state subsidies paid to striking workers. By resuming work, Stresemann reopened diplomatic channels with France and Britain, creating the essential foundation for economic stabilization and international reconciliation.

[1.2] In November 1923, Stresemann and newly appointed currency commissioner **Hjalmar Schacht** introduced the temporary **Rentenmark**. Because hyperinflation had destroyed gold reserves, the Rentenmark was secured by mortgages on Germany's agricultural and industrial land (**Source A**). One Rentenmark was strictly pegged to one trillion old paper marks. In August 1924, it was replaced by the permanent gold-backed **Reichsmark**, instantly ending hyperinflation, stabilizing prices, and restoring business confidence across the nation.

[1.2] **Stresemann's Policy of Fulfilment (*Erfüllungspolitik*):** Stresemann recognised that Germany could not overturn Versailles through military defiance. Instead, he pioneered a pragmatic foreign policy of 'fulfilment': by scrupulously honouring treaty obligations, he won the trust of Britain and the US. At the 1924 London Conference, he secured the evacuation of Franco-Belgian occupation troops from the Ruhr. By appointing Dr Hjalmar Schacht to head the Reichsbank under the 1924 Bank Act, Stresemann anchored the new Reichsmark to gold and guaranteed strict central bank independence.

[1.3] **The Rentenmark Miracle & Currency Stabilization:** In November 1923, Stresemann appointed currency commissioner Hjalmar Schacht to introduce the Rentenmark, backed by a mortgage on all German agricultural and industrial land. By strictly limiting the money supply to 3.2 billion Rentenmarks, Schacht restored public confidence, permanently ending hyperinflation. In August 1924, the permanent Reichsmark backed by gold reserves replaced it under the Dawes Plan reforms.

[1.4] **The Locarno Treaties (1925) & League of Nations (1926):** Stresemann's crowning diplomatic triumphs restored Germany as an equal Great Power. In the 1925 Locarno Treaties, Germany voluntarily accepted its western frontiers with France and Belgium, securing peace in Western Europe and winning the 1926 Nobel Peace Prize. In September 1926, Germany was formally admitted to the League of Nations as a permanent Council member, ending its post-war diplomatic isolation.

SOURCE A PRIVATE CORRESPONDENCE — September 1928

Gustav Stresemann on the Fragility of the Economic Recovery

> *"Our economic recovery is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is, in fact, dancing on a volcano. If our American creditors should ever decide to call in their short-term loans, a very large section of our industrial and commercial economy will collapse immediately."*

From a private letter written by Foreign Minister Gustav Stresemann in autumn 1928, candidly acknowledging that Weimar's apparent golden prosperity was dangerously vulnerable to any sudden recall of Wall Street credit.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did Stresemann privately describe Germany's economic position as 'dancing on a volcano' despite rising industrial output?*

ACT 2 WALL STREET GOLD: THE DAWES PLAN AND THE INFLUX OF AMERICAN LOANS (1924)

[2.1] With currency stability restored, Stresemann addressed the reparations crisis through the **Dawes Plan** of April 1924, formulated by American banker Charles G. Dawes (Charles Dawes). The plan restructured reparations to match Germany's economic capacity: annual payments started at a manageable 1 billion marks, gradually rising to 2.5 billion marks over five years. Furthermore, French and Belgian troops evacuated the Ruhr, ending military occupation.

[2.2] Crucially, the Dawes Plan arranged an immediate foreign loan of 800 million gold marks ($200 million) from Wall Street to underpin the Reichsbank. Over the next five years, vast **American loans and investment** totaling over 25 billion marks flowed into German industry. Heavy conglomerates like Krupp, Thyssen, and IG Farben modernized machinery, while municipal councils built schools, public swimming baths, and modern apartment blocks. By 1928, German industrial production surpassed pre-war 1913 levels, making Germany Europe's leading manufacturing powerhouse.

[3.1] Stresemann recognized that economic revival required peaceful diplomacy, pursuing a strategy of *Erfüllungspolitik* (fulfillment). His diplomacy achieved historic success in gaining the **international acceptance of Germany** among world powers. In October 1925, Stresemann signed the **Locarno Pact** (a series of treaties signed at Locarno, Switzerland) alongside Britain, France, Italy, and Belgium (**Source B**). For the first time since 1918, Germany was welcomed as an equal diplomatic partner rather than a defeated outlaw state.

[3.2] Under the **Locarno Pact**, Germany voluntarily guaranteed its western borders with France and Belgium, renouncing historic claims to Alsace-Lorraine and accepting the permanent demilitarisation of the Rhineland. In return, France agreed never to invade Germany again. Stresemann deliberately left eastern frontiers open to future peaceful revision. For this diplomatic breakthrough, Stresemann and French Foreign Minister Aristide Briand were jointly awarded the 1926 Nobel Peace Prize.

[2.3] **The Young Plan (1929) & The 'Liberty Law' Nationalist Backlash:** Chaired by American industrialist Owen D. Young, the 1929 agreement reduced total German reparations from £6.6 billion to £2 billion, lowered annual payments, and extended the timetable to 1988 while securing the complete withdrawal of Allied occupation troops from the Rhineland five years ahead of schedule. However, right-wing nationalists led by Alfred Hugenberg and Adolf Hitler fiercely denounced the plan, mobilising press networks to campaign against the 'enslavement of German grandchildren'.

[2.4] **Dancing on a Volcano: The Fragility of American Loans:** Beneath the surface of prosperity lay acute economic vulnerability. Germany borrowed nearly 25 billion marks from Wall Street between 1924 and 1929, largely in callable short-term loans. While cities built schools and parks, Germany ran a constant trade deficit, and agriculture remained in severe depression. Stresemann himself issued a prophetic warning in late 1928: "Germany is dancing on a volcano. If American short-term loans are called in, our entire economy will collapse."

SOURCE B PRESS ANALYSIS — Late 1928

German Financial Press on Industrial Modernisation and the Dawes Plan

> *"Our national economy has finally achieved genuine stability. Through the Dawes Plan and massive American investment, our factories have been modernized with advanced assembly-line techniques, causing industrial production to soar. Support for extremist parties has collapsed, proving that our citizens are contented and that the Republic is finally safe."*

Article published in a leading German commercial daily newspaper celebrating five years of economic recovery under currency stabilisation, industrial rationalisation, and foreign capital inflows.

HINGE QUESTION: *How does Source B's optimistic assessment of German industrial stability directly contradict Stresemann's warning in Source A?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.3 — EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

RENTENMARK
Temporary stable currency introduced by Stresemann in Nov 1923, backed by mortgages on German agricultural and industrial land.

DAWES PLAN (1924)
Agreement scaling annual German reparations payments to economic capacity and injecting 800 million gold marks in American loans.

LOCARNO TREATIES (1925)
Pact where Germany voluntarily recognized its western borders with France and Belgium, securing peace in the West.

YOUNG PLAN (1929)
Agreement reducing total German reparations from £6.6bn to £2bn and extending payments over 59 years.

KT1.3: The Recovery of the Republic, 1924–1929

ACT 3 RETURN TO THE WORLD STAGE: GERMANY JOINS THE LEAGUE OF NATIONS (SEP 1926)

[4.1] The diplomatic momentum generated by the Locarno Pact paved the way for Germany's formal admission into the **League of Nations** in September 1926 (**Source C**). Rejecting initial French hesitation, the League Council unanimously invited Germany to join, awarding it a prestigious permanent seat on the Council alongside Great Britain, France, and Japan. This confirmed Germany's complete rehabilitation as a respected great power.

[4.2] A permanent Council seat enabled Stresemann to use international law to protect German minorities living in Poland and Czechoslovakia under Versailles border settlements. Stresemann further demonstrated Germany's peaceful commitment by signing the **Kellogg-Briand Pact** in August 1928 alongside sixty-two nations, renouncing war as an instrument of national policy. These international triumphs enhanced the Republic's prestige and caused extremist votes to plummet in the mid-1920s.

[3.2] **The Treaty of Berlin (1926) & Eastern Foreign Policy:** While securing peace in the west via Locarno, Stresemann deliberately refused to guarantee Germany's eastern borders with Poland and Czechoslovakia. To maintain diplomatic leverage against Britain and France, he signed the Treaty of Berlin in April 1926 with the Soviet Union, reaffirming mutual neutrality and covert military cooperation initiated under the 1922 Rapallo Pact.

HISTORICAL EVIDENCE LEAGUE OF NATIONS ADDRESS 10 September 1926

Gustav Stresemann's Address to the League of Nations Assembly

"It cannot be the purpose of the League of Nations to measure nations by their military might or the size of their armies. The League must be a fellowship of nations founded upon justice, moral strength, and international cooperation... Germany enters this great assembly with the sincere will to serve peace and to cooperate in solving the great tasks that history has set before mankind."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1878–1929



Gustav Stresemann
CHANCELLOR (1923) AND FOREIGN MINISTER OF GERMANY (1923–1929)

Rescued the Republic from hyperinflation, rebuilt diplomatic relations with the Western Allies, and secured foreign capital to finance German economic recovery.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Ended passive resistance in the Ruhr in September 1923 despite furious right-wing nationalist outcry.
- Introduced the temporary Rentenmark backed by land mortgages, halting hyperinflation and stabilizing the currency.
- Negotiated the Dawes Plan (1924), signed the Locarno Treaties (1925), brought Germany into the League of Nations (1926), and agreed the Young Plan (1929).

ACT 4 DANCING ON A VOLCANO: THE KELLOGG-BRIAND PACT, THE YOUNG PLAN AND HIDDEN VULNERABILITIES (1928–1929)

[5.1] The crowning achievement of Stresemann's economic diplomacy was the **Young Plan** of 1929, chaired by American banker Owen D. Young (Owen Young). Combined with the earlier 1924 Dawes Plan, the **Dawes and Young Plans** permanently stabilized reparations. The Young Plan slashed Germany's total reparations bill from £6.6 billion to £2 billion—a massive reduction—with annual instalments spread over fifty-nine years until 1988. In return, Allied occupation troops withdrew from the Rhineland in June 1930, five years ahead of schedule.

[5.2] Despite these dramatic achievements, Weimar's economic recovery harbored fatal structural vulnerabilities. Prosperity was dangerously dependent on short-term American loans that could be recalled at any moment. Stresemann warned presciently in 1928: *"The economic position is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is dancing on a volcano."* When Stresemann died of a stroke on 3 October 1929, the volcano erupted: the Wall Street Crash struck weeks later, pulling the plug on American credit and pitching Germany into disaster.

[4.2] **Structural Flaws: Agriculture & Unemployment:** German agriculture entered deep depression from 1927 due to falling grain prices, fueling rural discontent. Crucially, even during the peak boom of 1928–29, unemployment never dropped below 1.3 million workers.

FINANCIAL ARCHITECTURE: BORROWED TIME THE DAWES LOAN CYCLE • 1924–1929

The Dawes Plan & "Dancing on a Volcano"

The 1924 Dawes Plan established a circular economic mechanism that temporarily stabilized Europe: American banks loaned billions of dollars to German municipal governments and industrial syndicates; Germany used this influx of capital to rebuild infrastructure, modernize factories, and pay reparations to Britain and France; Britain and France then used these reparation payments to pay off their wartime loans to the United States. While this created a dramatic boom, it created a fatal dependency: German businesses were financed by short-term loans that American financiers could recall on ninety days' notice.

Fatal Dependency: Stresemann himself warned in 1928: "The economic position is only flourishing on the surface. Germany is dancing on a volcano." When Wall Street crashed, the entire house of cards collapsed.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE STRESEMANN: EUROPEAN STATESMAN OR REVISIONIST?

Interpretation A: Multi-Lateral Peacemaker (Jonathan Wright)
"Stresemann was a visionary European statesman who understood that Germany's revival depended on international reconciliation. Locarno and the League represented sincere efforts to integrate Germany into a peaceful West."

Interpretation B: Tactical Nationalist (A.J.P. Taylor)
"Stresemann's 'policy of fulfilment' was merely a shrewd manoeuvre to liberate the Rhineland and dismantle Versailles without war. Meanwhile, funding recovery through fragile US loans left Germany dancing on a financial volcano."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ENQUIRY 1.3 SEQUENCE

Nov 1923 • The Rentenmark Introduced
Stresemann and Schacht issue the Rentenmark backed by land mortgages, destroying hyperinflation within weeks.

Aug 1924 • The Dawes Plan
Reparations are rescheduled and $3bn in US loans flow to German industry, triggering the "Golden Twenties".

Oct 1925 • The Locarno Treaties
Germany accepts its western frontiers with France and Belgium, securing European reconciliation and peace.

Sep 1926 • League of Nations Entry
Germany is admitted as a permanent Council member, restoring Great Power status; Young Plan follows in 1929.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B QUESTION 3(a) • 8 MARKS • 12 MINS

Exam Challenge: How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the economic recovery of the Weimar Republic in the years 1924–1929? [8 marks]

Specification Technique: Interrogate Content, Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose), and Context for both sources before reaching a weighed judgment. **GRADE 9 UTILITY**

KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929

Key Enquiry: A Golden Age or a divided nation: To what extent did the lives of workers, women, and artists genuinely improve during the Weimar Republic's era of recovery? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 WAGES, TENEMENTS AND PENSIONS: STANDARD OF LIVING AND UNEMPLOYMENT INSURANCE IN THE TWENTIES (1924–1928)

[1.1] The Golden Years brought significant improvements in the **standard of living** for ordinary German workers. As industrial recovery accelerated, real wages rose steadily, increasing by 9% in 1927 and 12% in 1928, giving German industrial employees some of the highest living standards in Europe. The working day was capped at eight hours, allowing unprecedented leisure time, while state health insurance covered over 35 million citizens.

[1.2] In 1927, the Reichstag passed the landmark **Unemployment Insurance Act**, creating a national welfare system funded by joint employer and worker contributions that protected 17 million workers against sudden destitution. The Weimar state also poured billions into municipal public housing, constructing over 2 million modern homes with indoor bathrooms and gardens between 1924 and 1931. Over 750,000 disabled war veterans, 400,000 war widows, and 900,000 orphans received state pensions, transforming the **standard of living**, though high taxes angered conservative industrialists.

[1.2] **Municipal Housing & Progressive Social Welfare:** Between 1924 and 1931, municipal building associations such as GEHAG constructed more than two million high-quality modern homes with electric lighting and indoor plumbing, significantly reducing overcrowding and tuberculosis in working-class districts. In 1927, the Reichstag passed the landmark Unemployment Insurance Act, providing contributory benefits to over 17 million workers—the most comprehensive social safety net in Europe.

SOURCE A OFFICIAL STATISTICAL RECORD 16 July 1927

Reichstag Report on the 1927 Unemployment Insurance Act & War Pensions

> *"Under the Reich Law of 16 July 1927, compulsory unemployment insurance is established for 17.2 million industrial and clerical workers, funded equally by employers and employees... In addition, the Reich Treasury continues to disburse pensions to 1,537,000 disabled war veterans, 533,000 war widows, and 1,192,000 orphans from the 1914–1918 war."*

While the 1927 Act established Europe's most advanced social safety net, the fixed financial burden severely restricted the government's fiscal manoeuvrability when mass unemployment struck in 1929.

HINGE QUESTION: *Was the Weimar welfare system a triumph of progressive social justice or an unsustainable economic gamble?*

ACT 2 THE BUBIKOPF AND THE VOTE: THE EMANCIPATION AND CLASHES OF THE 'NEW WOMAN' (1924–1929)

[2.1] The Weimar era witnessed profound changes in the **position of women** in work, politics and leisure. Under the 1919 Constitution, women gained full equal voting rights at age twenty, achieving a 90% turnout in Reichstag elections; between 1919 and 1932, 112 female deputies were elected to the national parliament. In employment, 1.7 million women entered teaching, medicine, civil service clerical roles, and retail, achieving financial independence.

[2.2] In urban centers like Berlin, financial freedom revolutionized the position of women in leisure and appearance. The modern **"New Woman"** (*Neue Frau*) (**Source A**) sported fashionable cropped "Bubikopf" short hair, smoked cigarettes, wore short skirts, and enjoyed unchaperoned evenings in cabarets, cinemas, and sports clubs. However, traditionalists, conservative churchmen, and right-wing nationalists condemned the New Woman as immoral and un-German, demanding that women abandon work, return to the domestic sphere, and embrace the traditional family and the Three Ks: *Kinder, Küche, Kirche* (Children, Kitchen, Church).

[3.1] The mid-1920s witnessed extraordinary **cultural changes: developments in architecture, art and the cinema** flourished under constitutional freedom of expression. In architecture, Walter Gropius founded the famous **Bauhaus** school of design in Weimar in 1919, relocating to iconic purpose-built glass-and-steel premises in Dessau in 1925 (**Source B**). Bauhaus rejected fussy imperial ornamentation, pioneering modernist functionalism under the slogans *"form follows function"* and *"art into industry."*

[3.2] Bauhaus master architects like Ludwig Mies van der Rohe and Marcel Breuer designed sleek tubular steel chairs, minimalist light fittings, and affordable municipal housing blocks. Bauhaus buildings utilized reinforced concrete, clean geometric lines, and expansive glass curtain walls that flooded interiors with natural light. While celebrated internationally as cutting-edge modernity, conservative critics loathed Bauhaus flat roofs, branding them "alien, communist, and un-German."

[2.3] **The Patriarchal Backlash & 'Double-Earners' (*Doppelverdiener*):** Despite constitutional protections under Article 109, women encountered fierce institutional resistance. Conservative political parties, the Catholic and Lutheran churches, and the national civil service association fiercely attacked married working women as 'double-earners' (*Doppelverdiener*) who were accused of stealing jobs from demobilised war veterans. By 1932, Chancellor Heinrich Brüning passed emergency decrees enabling the dismissal of married female civil servants if their husbands were employed. Outside cosmopolitan Berlin, traditional patriarchal expectations remained deeply entrenched: the vast majority of provincial women remained full-time domestic homemakers, while abortion remained heavily criminalised under Section 218.

SOURCE B CONSTITUTIONAL CHARTER 11 August 1919

Article 109 of the Weimar Constitution

> *"All Germans are equal before the law. Men and women have, in principle, the same fundamental civic rights and duties. Marriage is based on the equality of the sexes and the preservation of the family... All exceptional provisions against female civil servants are abolished."*

Article 109 established legal equality and women's suffrage for the first time in German history, yet traditional conservative attitudes and economic backlash continued to limit female advancement in practice.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did formal constitutional equality fail to eliminate the social stigma of working women as 'double-earners'?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 1.4 EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

BAUHAUS
Revolutionary modernist design school founded by Walter Gropius, prioritizing clean functionality: "form follows function".

THE "NEW WOMAN"
Cultural ideal of the modern Weimar woman: financially independent, voting, wearing bobbed hair, and smoking in public.

NEUE SACHLICHKEIT
"New Objectivity"; realist art movement (e.g. Otto Dix, George Grosz) depicting gritty, cynical truths of post-war German society.

KULTURBOLSCHEWISMUS
"Cultural Bolshevism"; derogatory right-wing label used by nationalists to attack modern art, jazz, and liberated Berlin culture.

KT1.4: Changes in Society, 1924–1929

ACT 3 NEUE SACHLICHKEIT & WEIMAR CINEMA: OTTO DIX, THE CABINET OF DR. CALIGARI AND MODERNIST IRONY (1924–1929)

[4.1] Parallel **cultural changes** transformed visual art and filmmaking. In art, painters rejected romanticism for **Neue Sachlichkeit** (New Objectivity), depicting post-war German society with savage realism. Artists like **Otto Dix** and **George Grosz** painted biting social critiques, contrasting corrupt war profiteers in glamorous nightclubs with maimed, limbless war veterans begging in Berlin gutters.

[4.2] In cinema, Weimar Germany became the creative film capital of the world. Babelsberg studios produced groundbreaking expressionist cinema, including Robert Wiene's psychological horror *The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari* (1920) and Fritz Lang's visionary science-fiction epic *Metropolis* (1927). Berlin boasted over 900 avant-garde cabarets, satire clubs, and American-style jazz halls (**Source C**), establishing an atmosphere of total intellectual freedom and personal tolerance.

ACT 4 THE CONSERVATIVE BACKLASH: DEGENERACY ACCUSATIONS AND THE CULTURAL FAULT LINES OF THE REPUBLIC (1924–1929)

[5.1] These radical **cultural changes** provoked a venomous conservative backlash across provincial Germany. To rural farmers, religious Catholics, and the traditional middle class (*Mittelstand*), Berlin appeared as a decadent, sinful Babylon that was destroying Christian family values. They were deeply horrified by permissive nightlife, female emancipation, satirical cabaret attacks on the military, and visible LGBTQ+ subcultures in the capital.

[5.2] Right-wing nationalists and Adolf Hitler's Nazi Party weaponized this cultural resentment, denouncing modern art, cinema, films, and architecture as **"Kulturbolschewismus"** (Cultural Bolshevism) orchestrated by a Jewish-Marxist conspiracy to rot German morale. This profound cultural polarization fractured Weimar society: while urban progressives celebrated artistic liberation, millions of provincial Germans felt completely alienated from the Republic, creating fertile ground for authoritarian nationalism.

PRIMARY PLATE BAUHAUS DESSAU • 1926 — Architectural Plate

The Bauhaus Complex in Dessau, Designed by Walter Gropius



Gropius designed the Dessau complex with steel frames and continuous glass curtain walls, embodying modern functionalism.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did modern functionalist design provoke such intense hostility from traditional nationalists?*

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1883–1969



Walter Gropius

PIONEER MODERNIST ARCHITECT & FOUNDER OF THE BAUHAUS SCHOOL (1919–1928)

Revolutionized modern architecture and industrial design by uniting fine art with modern industrial technology, creating the iconic Weimar aesthetic.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Founded the Bauhaus in 1919 and designed the iconic glass-and-steel Dessau complex in 1925.
- Pioneered functionalist design ("form follows function"), championing accessible, mass-produced housing and furniture for modern industrial society.

POLARIZATION: KULTURBOLSCHEWISMUS — THE CULTURAL BACKLASH • 1924–1929

The Nationalist War on 'Cultural Bolshevism'

While international visitors celebrated Berlin as the glittering capital of modernism, provincial and conservative Germans viewed Weimar culture with visceral horror. Traditionalists, the Catholic and Protestant churches, and right-wing nationalist groups (such as the DNVP and NSDAP) denounced modern art, cabaret, Bauhaus functionalism, and women's liberation as *Kulturbolschewismus* ("Cultural Bolshevism")–a degenerate conspiracy allegedly orchestrated by communists and Jews to destroy German moral values. In 1926, the Reichstag passed the 'Law to Protect Youth from Trash and Smut' to censor modern literature and art.

The Cultural Schism: Weimar culture did not unite the nation; it created an irreconcilable chasm between cosmopolitan, progressive Berlin and traditional, conservative rural Germany that right-wing extremists exploited to delegitimize the Republic.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE — WEIMAR CULTURE: GOLDEN AGE OR DANGEROUS DIVIDE?

Interpretation A: Cultural Renaissance (Peter Gay)
"The Weimar era was a magnificent explosion of modernism and human liberation. Freedom from imperial censorship enabled unprecedented breakthroughs in Bauhaus architecture, expressionist art, and social emancipation."

Interpretation B: Polarizing Alienation (Gordon Craig)
"Avant-garde Berlin culture was an isolated phenomenon that horrified conservative, rural Germany. By flouting traditional morality, it fueled nationalist rage against 'cultural Bolshevism', directly aiding Nazi propaganda."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS — ENQUIRY 1.4 SEQUENCE

Aug 1919 • Article 109 Gender Equality
Women gain the vote at 20; by 1926, 32 female deputies sit in the Reichstag, pioneering social rights.

1925 • Bauhaus Moves to Dessau
Walter Gropius unveils the glass-and-steel Bauhaus complex, pioneering modernist architecture and functional design.

16 Jul 1927 • Unemployment Insurance Act
Landmark welfare law creates contributory insurance providing unemployment pay for over 17 million workers.

1928–1929 • Conservative Backlash
Traditionalists and churches attack "Cultural Bolshevism", modern cabaret, and financially independent "New Women".

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B — QUESTION 3(d) • 16 MARKS + 4 SPaG • 25 MINS

Exam Challenge: How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about the position of women in the Weimar Republic? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. [16 marks]

Specification Technique: Weigh Interpretation 1 against Interpretation 2; deploy precise contextual evidence; sustain a criteria-led historical verdict. **GRADE 9 VERDICT**

KEY TOPIC 1 REVISION SPINE: CORE KNOWLEDGE & EXAM STRATEGY

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1) History • Paper 3 Option 31 (1HI0/31) • Key Topic 1 Synthesis

1. KEY CHRONOLOGY • CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

KEY CHRONOLOGY

28 Oct 1918: Kiel Naval Mutiny: Sailors refuse suicidal attack; sparks nationwide revolution and soldiers' councils.

9 Nov 1918: Abdication of Wilhelm II: Kaiser flees to Holland; Scheidemann proclaims Republic to pre-empt communism.

11 Nov 1918: Armistice Signed: Matthias Erzberger signs surrender at Compiègne; fuels right-wing 'Dolchstoß' myth.

15 Jan 1919: Spartacist Revolt Crushed: Freikorps crush Berlin uprising; Rosa Luxemburg & Karl Liebknecht murdered.

28 Jun 1919: Versailles Treaty Signed: Weimar envoys forced to sign 'Diktat'; loses 13% land, 100k army limit, £6.6bn bill.

11 Aug 1919: Weimar Constitution Enacted: Progressive democracy ratified; introduces Proportional Representation & Article 48.

Mar 1920: The Kapp Putsch: 12,000 Freikorps seize Berlin; army refuses to fire; defeated by general workers' strike.

Jan 1923: Occupation of the Ruhr: 60,000 French/Belgian troops seize industry; passive resistance triggers hyperinflation.

Nov 1923: Rentenmark Currency Reform: Stresemann halts passive resistance; mortgage-backed currency restores stability.

Aug 1924: The Dawes Plan: Scales reparations to capacity; US banks loan 800m gold marks to revive German industry.

Oct 1925: The Locarno Treaties: Germany voluntarily accepts western borders with France/Belgium; secures European peace.

Sep 1926: League of Nations Entry: Germany admitted to League Council as a permanent Great Power; ends diplomatic isolation.

2. CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES

SPECIFICATION REVIEW

I. CONSTITUTIONAL FLAWS

Pure Proportional Representation (1 seat per 60k votes) prevented majorities, producing 20 fragile coalitions in 14 years. Article 48 allowed the President to rule by decree, creating a fatal dictatorial loophole.

II. EXTREMIST VIOLENCE

Right-wing Dolchstoß myth branded republicans "November Criminals". Armed coups from left (Spartacists 1919) and right (Kapp 1920, Munich 1923) exposed state dependence on unloyal imperial soldiers.

III. ECONOMIC RECOVERY

Halting passive resistance and issuing the Rentenmark halted hyperinflation. Dawes (1924) & Young (1929) Plans rebuilt industry on American credit—creating what Stresemann called "dancing on a volcano".

IV. CULTURAL POLARIZATION

Abolishing censorship unleashed avant-garde Bauhaus design, cinema, and the liberated "New Woman". However, provincial conservatives fiercely condemned Berlin culture as "cultural Bolshevism".

3. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY

EXAM STRATEGY • Q3(B,C,D)

INTERPRETATION 1: THE DOOMED REPUBLIC (KOLB / PEUKERT)

Weimar democracy was mortally wounded at birth by Versailles, Article 48, and unrepentant imperial civil servants and judges who subverted democracy. Stresemann's prosperity was an artificial bubble built on volatile US loans that inevitably burst in 1929.

INTERPRETATION 2: THE RESILIENT GOLDEN AGE (EVANS / BOOKBINDER)

Between 1924 and 1929, the Republic demonstrated remarkable resilience, weathering revolutionary coups and hyperinflation to build modern housing, progressive welfare, and peaceful diplomatic integration. Extremist votes collapsed to just 2.6% in 1928.

Q1: INFERENCE [4m]	Q2: CAUSATION [12m]	Q3(a): UTILITY [8m]	Q3(b/c): VIEWS [8m]	Q3(d): VERDICT [16+4m]
5 Mins • 2 Inferences + Quotes	15 Mins • 3 PEEL Causal Factors	12 Mins • Content, NOP & Context	10 Mins • Differences & Reasons	25 Mins • Balanced Evaluation

4. SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT • HISTORICAL VERDICT

EVALUATION & SIGNIFICANCE

DEMOCRACY ON TRIAL:

The Republic demonstrated surprising resilience in overcoming the 1919–1923 existential crises. By 1928, moderate coalition parties won 73% of the vote, and political assassinations had ceased. However, PR prevented stable parliamentary majorities, and Article 48 established a fatal habit of executive rule.

ECONOMIC ILLUSION:

Industrial output surpassed 1913 levels by 1928, and real wages rose steadily. Yet prosperity was an illusion financed by volatile American short-term loans. When Gustav Stresemann warned that Germany was "dancing on a volcano", he correctly foresaw that any US credit contraction would trigger catastrophic collapse.

SOCIAL & DIPLOMATIC LEGACY:

The Locarno Treaties and entry into the League of Nations restored Germany's great power status without firing a single shot. However, the psychological trauma of 1923 hyperinflation and conservative fury against modern Berlin culture left deep societal divisions that right-wing extremists would readily exploit.

5. INTERACTIVE QUIZZING HUB • SCAN WITH SMARTPHONE CAMERA

20-QUESTION PRACTICE QUIZZES

KT 1.1	KT 1.2	KT 1.3	KT 1.4
Origins of Republic	Early Challenges 1919–23	Recovery 1924–29	Society & Culture
INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ	INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ